

What else to watch: *8½* (1963) ■ *My Night at Maud's* (1969) ■ *Scenes from a Marriage* (1973) ■ *Sleeper* (1973) ■ *Manhattan* (1979) ■ *Hannah and Her Sisters* (1986) ■ *Deconstructing Harry* (1997) ■ *Blue Jasmine* (2013)

The self-absorption of the New York set is central to *Annie Hall*, and Alvy epitomizes it. In many ways the movie is an evolution of Allen's stand-up routine, in which he made comedy out of his own insecurities and preoccupations. The movie opens with a monologue to camera in which Alvy sums up his problems with women by quoting Groucho Marx's famous comment: "I would never want to belong to any club that would have someone like me for a member." Of his first wife Allison, Alvy later says: "Why did I turn off Allison Portchnik? She was—she was beautiful. She was willing. She was real... intelligent. Is it the old Groucho Marx joke?"

"We need the eggs"

Throughout the movie, Alvy explores what makes a successful relationship and why relationships fail, even asking people randomly on the street. But it seems that his search is

Woody Allen Director/Actor

Born Allen Konigsberg in Brooklyn, New York, in 1935, Woody Allen's New York Jewish background would become a key theme in his movies. He started out writing jokes for newspapers and television before becoming a stand-up comic in the early 1960s, creating monologues that drew on his mix of intellect and self-doubt. By 1965, he was making movies, starting with

slapstick comedies before developing works that were influenced by European art-house movies. Allen continues to make a new movie almost every year.

Key movies

1977 *Annie Hall*
1979 *Manhattan*
1986 *Hannah and Her Sisters*

futile, since the relationships he encounters are fleeting and not particularly meaningful. One couple attributes happiness to their mutual shallowness and the fact that they have "nothing interesting to say."

In the end, Alvy has to admit that relationships are "totally irrational and crazy and absurd... but I guess we keep going through it because most of us need the eggs." This is a reference to a joke in which a man goes to a psychiatrist and tells him that his brother thinks he's a chicken. "The doctor

says, 'Well, why don't you turn him in?' And the guy says, 'I would, but I need the eggs.'" In this case, the eggs are love, and Annie is the love of Alvy's life. *Annie Hall* is Allen's analysis of how love goes wrong—how the eggs get broken. ■

Alvy (Woody Allen) keeps being drawn back to Annie (Diane Keaton), but he is doomed to fail in all his relationships.

